seeming to be on the verge of tears, and she told us that she had come to work for MaBaTha because of her desire to protect Buddhism. But her synthesis is not unique: in the course of the M.MAS listening project, as well as my own ethnographic research, I have heard others make varying permutations of these three strands of arguments, drawing on their own experiences, events in Myanmar, and events elsewhere in the world. In the following excerpt from an interview in Mawlamyine, for example, the narrator had just told us that he was afraid to interact with Muslims and we had begun discussing his reasons for such a feeling:

> Q: Can you give me some examples?
>
> A: I can give many examples of worldwide incidents. For example, they attacked the World Trade Center in America and you can also see [examples] in Myanmar. They are the sources of these incidents. Nowadays, we are more and more afraid of them and also you can see the situation of ISIS. I don't trust Islam in Myanmar because of this ISIS. For example, Islam [Muslims] from Indonesia are involved in ISIS, so nobody can say that Islam [Muslims] in Myanmar are not involved or participating in the processes of ISIS. That is why we are afraid of them.[13]

In the working paper in which my M.MAS colleagues and I detailed our research findings, we explored all three of these strands of argument, organized in spatial terms, and noted that fears and antagonism towards Muslims in Myanmar were more often justified through reference to international events and events elsewhere in Myanmar than those of personal experience (Schissler, Walton, and Phyu Phyu Thi 2015). Throughout our conversation with the narrator quoted above — a Buddhist man who owns a small business and is an active member of social work activities and opposition political work in his city — he wove together a variety of arguments about events in his area, Myanmar, and the world. But as the above excerpt shows, when given an opportunity to explain his feelings, he opted to emphasize them with reference to events outside Myanmar.

When I have commented on the apparent importance of these references to international events in academic settings, it has sometimes generated outright refusal of the kind that inspired this chapter. In other cases, it has generated questions about the nature of research encounters. Was my presence, as an American, prompting interlocutors in Myanmar to invoke a strand of arguments about international events that they might not